
Kanye West's latest controversy may look simple. Americans are missing something.

Published by

Estimated reading time

4 min

Added on

2026-04-08

Address

<https://slate.com/culture/2026/04/kanye-west-wireless-festival-ye-concert-uk-tour.html>

Kanye West's latest controversy may look simple. Americans are missing something.

Last week, Wireless, one of London's biggest summer music festivals, announced its headline act. That headline act was Kanye West. You know, Kanye West. The guy who released a song called "Heil Hitler" last year, sold T-shirts with swastikas on them only a few months earlier, and once announced on Twitter that he would go "death con 3 On JEWISH PEOPLE." What could go wrong?

It does not take a genius to work out why Wireless did this—the "comeback" performances of a disgraced global superstar will surely sell tickets—but I would argue it does take an idiot not to foresee that inviting a musician who has vocally supported Nazism to the U.K., at this moment, was a bad, bad idea. In any case, he's not coming. Today, the British government announced that it had refused to grant West authorization to enter the country. The Home Office told the BBC that the decision was made on the grounds that ["his presence would not be conducive to the public good."](#) And the entire festival has been cancelled as a result. The company issued a statement today, saying that "as with every Wireless Festival, multiple stakeholders were consulted in advance of booking Ye and no concerns were highlighted at the time." Who were they consulting? Their wallets?

West has recently been making noises about atoning for years of poisonous behavior and antisemitic rhetoric. In January, he took out a full page ad in the Wall Street Journal apologizing for his antisemitism. "I am not a Nazi or an antisemite," he wrote. "I love Jewish people." West has attributed his antisemitic behavior to suffering from bipolar type-1. Experts in bipolar type-1 [dispute the link](#) between the condition and the kind of hateful racism West has been spouting, however. In any case he has [apologized before](#), in 2023, after which he dove right back into making an album that included not only "Heil Hitler" but another track titled "Gas Chambers."

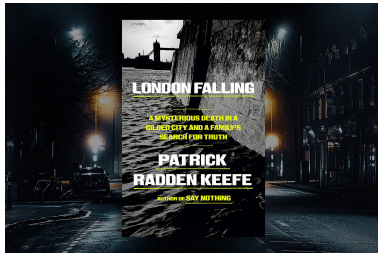
The refusal to grant West entry is not exactly unprecedented—Australia blocked him from entering their country last year, citing the "Heil Hitler" track. But Americans following the story from afar are likely to be missing quite a bit of context that's specific to the U.K.

Antisemitism is one of the hottest topics going in the U.K. at the moment. There is a very real and urgent need to protect the Jewish population of the United Kingdom. Just last month, ambulances belonging to a Jewish charity group in north London were [set on fire in what is being treated as a hate crime](#). A man [stabbed worshippers at a synagogue in Manchester on Yom Kippur last year](#). Since the Gaza war, Jewish people in the U.K. have been targets of increased aggression.

And antisemitism is an accusation that has plagued the Labour party in particular in the past decade. A dominant media narrative that Jeremy Corbyn, leader of the Labour party between 2015 and 2020, was antisemitic for being anti-Zionist, went a long way to costing him the 2019 election. Prime Minister Keir Starmer, who took over the party after Corbyn, is no doubt therefore keenly aware that it cannot be seen to be going easy on anti-Jewish sentiment of any kind. Hence Starmer's refusal to back the findings of organizations like the International Association of Genocide Scholars by condemning Israel's actions in Palestine as genocidal, which has been a major factor in his unpopularity here. Last year, Starmer's government made support of a pro-Palestine activism group, Palestine Action, illegal, on the grounds that it was a "terrorist group," with the result that peaceful retirees were being dragged away by police for wearing signs saying "I oppose genocide. I support Palestine Action." (The U.K.'s High Court later declared the ban [unlawful](#).)

All of which is to say that anything related to antisemitism is, in the U.K.,, even more charged than usual, and in light of that, it seems like an especially astonishing miscalculation by Wireless to think that someone who has publicly supported Hitler would be welcomed by the British government at this time.

Related From Slate



Laura Miller

A Teen Fell to His Death in London. Behind the Tragedy Lay So Much More.

[Read More](#)

And the British government having to step in to prevent West from performing here may now have unpleasant consequences. It does not sit easy that the Home Office has the power to dictate which artists may or may not perform here. Besides, is this step, cancelling a popular music festival, not the kind of thing that might prompt antisemitic backlash, if certain deeply misguided people decide that Jewish Brits are responsible for them not getting to enjoy themselves? Underneath Starmer's post about West's denied entry to the U.K., there are already comments along the lines of "oh so we can't have kanye west but we're fine with having third world terrorists in our country?"

It's a mess. The only solution, really, is that he should never have been invited in the first place. But there are some things you can't take back.

Get the best of culture

Get the best of movies, TV, books, music, and more.

Thanks for signing up! You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

You're already subscribed to the Culture newsletter. You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

We encountered an issue signing you up. Please try again, or [manage all your newsletter subscriptions here](#) .

Please enable javascript to sign up for newsletters.

Email address:

Send me updates about Slate special offers.

By signing up, you agree to our [Privacy Policy](#) and [Terms](#).

Sign Up

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.